WILDLIFE FIELD GUIDE

The Lion

Panthera leo is the only truly social cat. Prides of related females and their cubs, with coalitions of males, define its life in the savannas of Africa and a small population in India's Gir Forest.

Lion in Serengeti National Park

Photo: Wikimedia Commons, Serengeti National Park.

Biology at a Glance

Trait	Typical value
Scientific name	Panthera leo
Male weight	150 to 250 kg
Female weight	120 to 180 kg
Gestation	About 110 days
Daily rest	16 to 20 hours
Wild lifespan	About 10 to 14 years

Females do most of the cooperative hunting and raise cubs communally. Males defend territory and the pride against rival coalitions, and they eat first at a kill.

Four-month-old lion cub

Photo: Wikimedia Commons, Kalahari lion cub, four months old.

Conservation Status

The IUCN lists the lion as Vulnerable. Habitat loss, conflict with livestock herders, and declining prey populations are the main threats across Africa.

Protected areas, community-based conservation, and compensation schemes for livestock losses are the most widely used responses.

Key Takeaways

Lions are the most social wild cats, and their survival depends on large connected landscapes, healthy prey populations, and coexistence with people.